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LIFE & WORKTRAVELOFF DUTY TRAVEL

Djerba: The Ancient Tunisian Island Where Contemporary Art Is King

ome for the bougainvillea-draped alleys and picturesque guest houses—stay for the pioneering street art project that has transformed this vibrant Mediterranean village into an open-air gallery



CANVAS THE NEIGHBORHOOD A bold Elphège MyFactory mural decorates the exterior of the lavishly restored Dar Bibine guesthouse.

By Abbie Kozolchyk / Photographs by Chedly Ben Ibrahim for The Wall Street Journal

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JUST OFF TUNISIA’S southeastern coast sits a spot with a long history of intriguing names, from the Odyssean Land of the Lotus-Eaters to the Flaubertian Island of Golden Sand. But a decidedly modern moniker turned out to be the one I couldn’t resist: Djerbahood. It’s a new handle for an ancient village on the island of Djerba, where street art has transformed the weather-beaten walls into a sprawling open-air gallery.

I’d long been meaning to visit, drawn to the singular coexistence between Djerba’s ancient Jewish and Muslim communities—and tempted by the occasional sand-and-sea postcard from a Parisian friend (one of the legions of Europeans and North Africans who retreat regularly to the island’s beach resorts). When I started seeing news of a fresh wave of art installations this year, I finally booked my trip.

The exhibit’s French-Tunisian mastermind—Galerie Itinerrance founder Mehdi Ben Cheikh—knows something of neighborhood transformations. In 2013, enlisting more than 100



international street artists, he turned a condemned housing tower in Paris’s 13th arrondissement into a cultural sensation. Thousands of people waited in hours-long lines to experience the newly dubbed La Tour Paris 13 for the month it was open. Then, having pulled off Europe’s largest group street-art show to date, Mr. Ben Cheikh set his sights across the Mediterranean.

“The goal, quite simply, was to create the ideal street-art museum,” he said during an interview. Djerba’s tucked-away enclave of Er Riadh, also known as Hara Sghira, presented the perfect opportunity: an entire village’s worth of walls—

“many abandoned and ruined, but all still suffused with a multicultural history and soul” that he found beautiful—where artists from around the world could work almost without limit. Before beginning the project, Mr. Ben Cheikh gained the express permission of the local residents, some of whom wanted a say in their walls’ adornment, others of whom gave the artists free rein.

The resulting exhibition has seen two major waves—the first in 2014, on the heels of the Tour Paris 13 success—and the second over the past year or so, to coincide with the forthcoming Sommet de la Francophonie, Nov. 19-20, when Emmanuel Macron, Justin Trudeau and other leaders of the French-speaking world are expected to convene on the island for the first time in the summit’s 18-year history. This year has also seen the formation of a new destination management organization and the successful completion of Djerba’s Unesco World Heritage application (with official inscription anticipated in 2023).

The combined effect is an island ready for its close-up, from infrastructure improvements to the first class of locally trained and certified professional guides—and I benefited mightily from the latter. But first, I decided to explore on my own, starting at La Ghriba, the oldest functioning synagogue in Africa and one of the most iconic structures in Djerbahood.



A calligraphic mural by the French-Tunisian street artist eL Seed.

According to tradition, La Ghriba houses everything from salvaged remnants of the Temple of Solomon to the tomb of a local saint, whose body reportedly appeared on the ground beneath the current sanctuary and inspired pilgrims to start leaving handwritten prayers there. I shimmied through knee-high cabinet doors and down a dim stairwell to take in the primal mystery of the place—but couldn't decipher much detail in the darkness. So I promptly reemerged to explore La Ghriba's maximalist conjoined halls—each a kaleidoscope of tilework, painted arches and stained glass. For all the compound's astonishing interior detail, however, it was the street-facing signpost that caught me especially off-guard. Just below the words "Synagogue La ghriba," was a tile menorah, its pixelated branches and flames the handiwork of a single possible artist: Invader.

An incognito French mosaicist known for his global following and style inspired by vintage video games, he was the first of many street art A-listers whose work I started spotting at every turn—far more turns than I could keep track of in this maze of a village. Among the standouts were the faded 2014 calligraphy by the French-Tunisian phenom eL Seed and a trio of murals by Shepard Fairey, best known for his 2008 Obama Hope posters.



Outdoor art, like this piece by street artist Shepard Fairey, attracts contemporary art buffs from around the world.

Part of the joy was getting lost among the bougainvillea-draped alleys, where I never knew whose work might pop up next. (I was too early for the new map and QR code system, both scheduled for a late 2022 debut.) But I soon realized that a guide could help me see not only some of the art I wasn't finding on my own but also some of the island's other sights.

Dhouha Selmi, a graduate of the aforementioned guide pilot program, served as my escort. Even if she didn't know the exact location of, say, the Arabic and Hebrew calligraphic installation I'd hoped to see (a joint Djerbahood project by Muslim and Jewish scribes), she'd soon be patting the back of a newfound local friend who did.

Having gorged on seemingly all the local art and brik (a stuffed savory pastry that's typical of Djerbahood's kosher snack shops), we moved on to the whitewashed seaside mosque of Sidi Yati. There, a group of pilgrims took to Ms. Selmi so quickly, they insisted we share their freshly prepared bsissa—a sublime blend of roasted durum, olive oil and honey—along with steaming mint tea. From there, we went to the old market in the island's capital, Houmt Souk, where Ms. Selmi led a master class in negotiating soap, spice and jewelry prices. And so our touring continued, until I had no more room in my belly or bags.

Like Ulysses among the island's mythic lotus-eaters, I'd lost all interest in leaving Djerba. But I consoled myself with an excuse to return: As long as Mr. Ben Cheikh kept bringing artists (as he planned to do for the foreseeable future), whatever happened next at this intersection of antiquity and modernity would be too good to miss.

THE LOWDOWN // A guide to visiting Djerba, Tunisia

Getting There: Djerba has an international airport with direct service to a number of

European cities (Paris, Brussels and Frankfurt are all about three hours away). You can also

fly from Tunis in about an hour, but driving down the coast with a service such as [MyDayTrip.com](https://www.mydaytrip.com) makes for a spectacular (if extremely long) day, with stops in Sidi Bou Said, Sousse, Monastir and El Jem, at a minimum—plus a quick ride on a ferry.



The peaceful pool area at the Dar Bibine guest house in Djerba.

Staying There: One of the first guesthouses to open its walls to Djerbahood’s artists (ask about the original Zepha mural), Dar Bibine (from \$90 a night) is lavishly adorned both outside and in. The Belgian expats who bought and restored this traditional village home decorate each guest room and public space with the exceptional artwork they’ve collected. They’ve also installed a small pool and offer an outstanding breakfast.

Eating and Drinking There: Snack your way through all the kosher brik shops of Djerbahood and the other main Jewish neighborhood, Hara Kebira. If you choose only one, make it Brik Ishak in Hara Kbira so you can spot the prized Invader character

by the shop’s name. As for the fillings, you can generally order any combination of egg, cheese, tuna and potato. For fine dining, head to the second of the guest houses that first opened their walls to Djerbahood’s artists, Dar Dhiafa, where you’ll now find Shepard Fairey’s work as well as a beautiful indoor-outdoor restaurant and lobby bar and exceptional couscous.

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